



CHARLES
STANLEY▲

Beauhurst

Female Founders

2024

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Foreword

In an era where innovation and entrepreneurship are more vital than ever, the voices of female founders are emerging as powerful catalysts for change. This report highlights the remarkable journeys of women who have not only broken barriers but have also redefined the landscape of business and leadership.

As we delve into the survey findings, case studies and insights shared within these pages, we recognise the unique challenges faced by female entrepreneurs—challenges that often stem from systemic biases and societal expectations. Yet, despite these hurdles, women continue to rise, innovate, and inspire. Their resilience and creativity are not just reshaping industries; they are paving the way for future generations of leaders.

The findings also emphasise the importance of a more inclusive environment. This is not simply about addressing inequalities but about recognising the value that diverse perspectives bring to innovation and problem-solving. By understanding these experiences and the broader patterns they reveal, stakeholders can better support an environment where all entrepreneurs have the potential to thrive. Investors, policymakers, mentors, and industry leaders have a role to play in fostering a more equitable landscape.

This report serves as both a testament to the achievements of female founders and a call to action for all stakeholders in the entrepreneurial ecosystem. It highlights the importance of fostering an inclusive environment where diverse voices can thrive. By amplifying these findings and stories, we hope to inspire collaboration, mentorship, and investment in women-led ventures. Supporting female founders is about unlocking opportunities that contribute to economic development and social change.

Together, let us champion the spirit of female entrepreneurship and work towards a future where every aspiring founder has the opportunity to succeed, regardless of gender.



Katrina Gane
Business Development Manager
Charles Stanley

Introduction

Female-founded businesses are a vital and dynamic force within the UK's entrepreneurial landscape. As of October 2024, there are 7,696 high-growth companies in the UK with at least one female founder, representing 13.7% of the country's high-growth ecosystem. Female-led enterprises contribute significantly to the nation's economy, with high-growth female-founded businesses employing approximately 330k people across the UK.

There remains a need to improve female business leaders' access to funding and empower them to create companies in industries that have strong investment potential. By supporting female founders in building scalable, high-growth businesses, we can expect to see a greater share of female-founded companies receiving equity investment, bringing this more in line with their male-founded counterparts.

Female founders tend to be between 30 and 40 years old when the business is founded, likely because entrepreneurs of this age have more business experience and are often more financially stable. There are, however, plenty of younger women starting businesses between the ages of 20 and 30. For these young entrepreneurs, the discrimination associated with being a female founder is even more pronounced.

Charles Stanley's Fortune Favours Survey reveals a strong sense of community and mutual support among female business owners in the UK, with 70.8% expressing a desire

to help other women and 72.8% committed to supporting young business leaders. Despite some progress in making the business environment more inclusive—46.0% agree that it is now easier to start a business compared to when they began—challenges persist. Experiences of sexism remain prevalent, as reported by over half of respondents.

“

63.2%

[of female business leaders]

feel they must work harder than men to be recognised as leaders”

As the UK strives towards a more inclusive and balanced entrepreneurial environment, it becomes increasingly clear that fostering gender equality benefits everyone. From greater investment in female-led businesses to enhancing diversity within investment firms, the nation's economic resilience and innovation potential are significantly strengthened by supporting women entrepreneurs. This report explores the demographics of female founders, investigates the challenges they face, and highlights some of the inspirational female entrepreneurs making waves in the high-growth ecosystem.

01

Why Charles Stanley supports entrepreneurs

Why Charles Stanley supports entrepreneurs

At Charles Stanley, we offer a comprehensive suite of services designed to meet the needs of entrepreneurs at every stage of their journey.

“We support entrepreneurs because they are the backbone of a healthy economy”

Entrepreneurs drive innovation, bring new products and services to market, and create employment opportunities. Our goal is to empower them to succeed, which, in turn, fuels economic progress.

From the start of our relationship, we will take the time to listen and understand your journey, your hopes, goals, and fears. We will offer you long-term support, we know that your needs will change over time. We work in synergy with legal, tax, and accountancy teams meaning we can build your investment portfolio to reflect your financial needs and lifestyle, aiming to ensure the highest level of integrated client service. We work with your tax adviser to maximise your tax efficiency across income, capital gains, and inheritance tax. Our team of advisers can also help you plan a business exit or transfer. We will structure your wealth flexibly, freeing your time to focus on personal ambitions, life responsibilities, and the big picture of your business strategy.

Our wealth management service involves dedicated financial planners and investment managers who will provide you with a holistic financial plan and personalised investment strategy. We will explore your financial requirements to create a plan that meets your goals, gives you confidence in your investment strategy, and forms a secure financial future for you and your loved ones.

For entrepreneurs seeking professional investment management, our bespoke investment service offers dedicated experts to handle your investments. You'll have direct contact with your investment manager, who will build a portfolio tailored to your personal circumstances, investment objectives, and risk appetite. This service can also accommodate specific preferences, such as responsible and ESG investing.

Our commitment to entrepreneurs extends beyond investment management. We offer holistic financial planning services that address various life stages and significant events - including succession planning and retirement - ensuring you and your family achieve financial security. Our range of planning tools and techniques can also help you become more tax-efficient with your savings.



Mia Kahrmanovic
Financial Planner
Charles Stanley



Katie Tasker
Senior Investment Manager
Charles Stanley

02

The UK's Female-led Businesses

The UK's Female-led Businesses

In today's business landscape, female-led businesses in the UK represent an underserved segment—facing funding gaps, limited networks, and biases, which may restrict their growth. A business is classified as female-led if at least one woman is present in the founding team. If women make up more than half of the founders, the business is considered predominantly female-led.

As of October 2024, there are 7,696 high-growth companies with at least one female founder in the UK, representing 13.7% of the UK's high-growth company population. Of these, 4,224 are predominantly female-founded.

Funding remains one of the most significant challenges for female-founded businesses, with survey findings revealing that only 24.8% of women believe it is easier to secure funding as a woman than a man. More than half (55.2%) of respondents also shared they feel they are under increased scrutiny due to their gender.

“Access to capital remains a barrier for women entrepreneurs, with less than 2% of equity funding going to female-founded businesses”

In the first three quarters of 2024, female-founded companies have raised a collective £1.48b in equity funding via 972 deals. Though significant, this figure is overshadowed by the resources flowing into male-led ventures. During the same period, businesses without female founders secured £9.28b—over six times the amount raised by female-founded businesses.

These figures highlight the higher share of equity flowing into male-led firms within the high-growth sector compared to female-led ones. This imbalance may stem from a range of factors, including the limited availability of equity finance, mentorship, and networking opportunities for women entrepreneurs. Increasing diversity within investment teams, for instance, could help address funding gaps, as research shows that female investors are more likely to support female founders.¹

The disparity in representation has catalysed a growing need for initiatives that support and scale female-led businesses. UK-based accelerators such as AccelerateHer focus specifically on fostering female entrepreneurship. Powered by Barclays Eagle Labs and funded by the UK government, AccelerateHer provides female founders in Scotland with free courses, in-person and virtual bootcamps, and targeted mentorship, aimed at accelerating business growth and enhancing visibility.

The number of female-founded businesses has more than doubled over the past decade and continues to grow. As this trend accelerates, scaling support for female-led companies will be crucial. From investment and mentorship programmes to diversity within investment firms, the business ecosystem stands to gain considerably from greater gender equality, resulting in a stronger, more resilient economy powered by diverse leadership.

“Businesses without female founders secured over six times the funding raised by female-founded companies in the first three quarters of 2024”

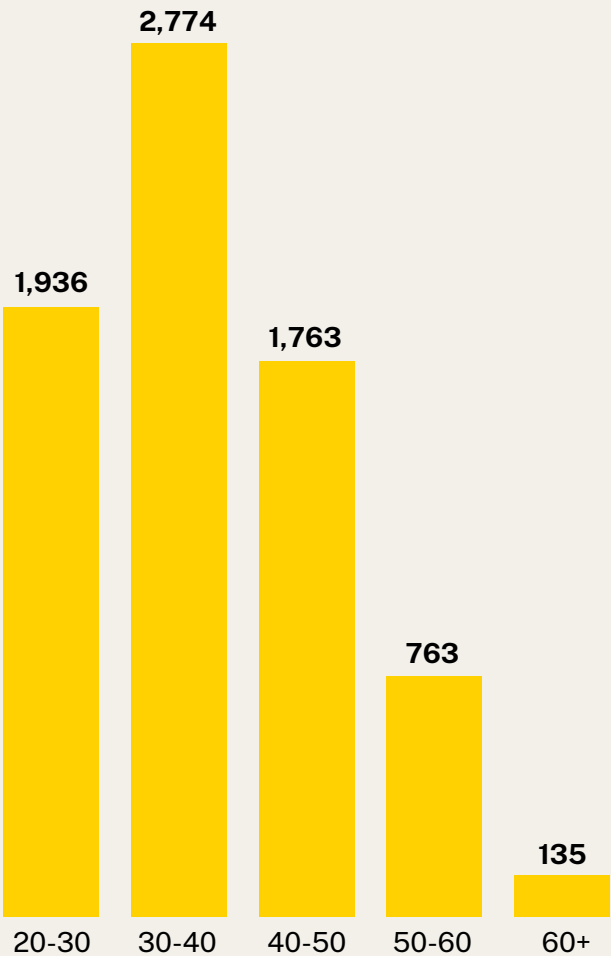
¹“Women VCs Invest in up to 2x More Female Founders.” Kauffman Fellows

03

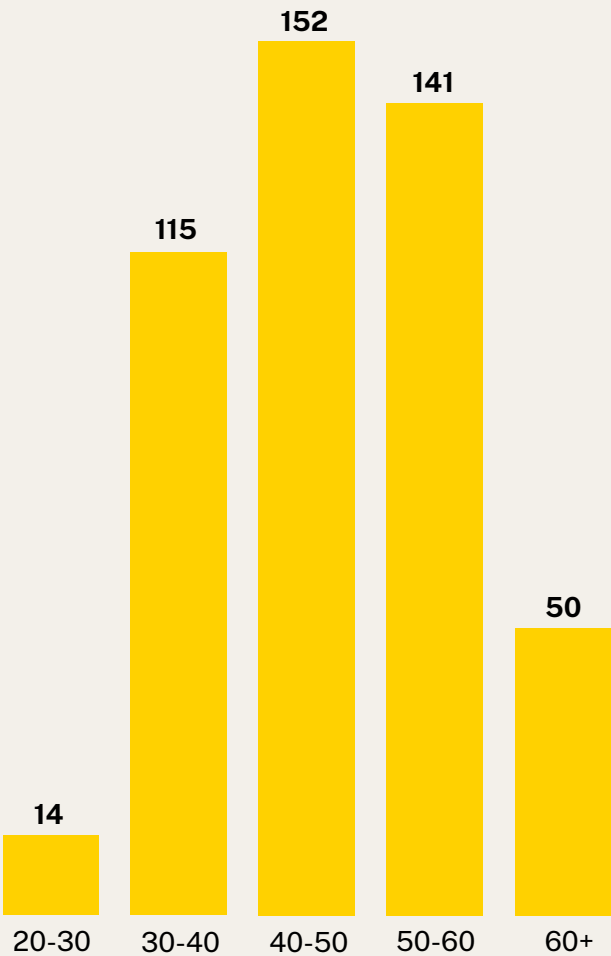
Female-founder demography

Female-founder demography

Number of female founders of high-growth companies by their age at incorporation date (Nov 2024)



Number of female founders of exited high-growth companies by their age at date of exit (Nov 2024)



Data on the age at incorporation for female founders shows a broad distribution of entry points into entrepreneurship. The largest proportion of female founders falls within the 30-40 age bracket. This distribution is likely due to the advantages of accumulated professional experience, established networks, and financial stability that often come with age. Such resources equip all founders—including female founders—to take on the risks associated with starting a business.

Nearly 2,000 female founders were between the ages of 20 and 30 when they started their businesses, highlighting that entrepreneurship is accessible to

women earlier in their careers. While founders across all age groups face challenges such as limited access to funding, these obstacles can be especially pronounced for younger founders who may have less experience and fewer established professional connections.

For female-led companies that achieve an exit, the most common age at which this occurs is between 40 and 50. The data also shows relatively few exits among companies where the founder’s age at the time of exit is between 20-30. Younger founders, though ambitious, may face a longer pathway to exit as they navigate early-stage hurdles, develop networks, and refine their business models.

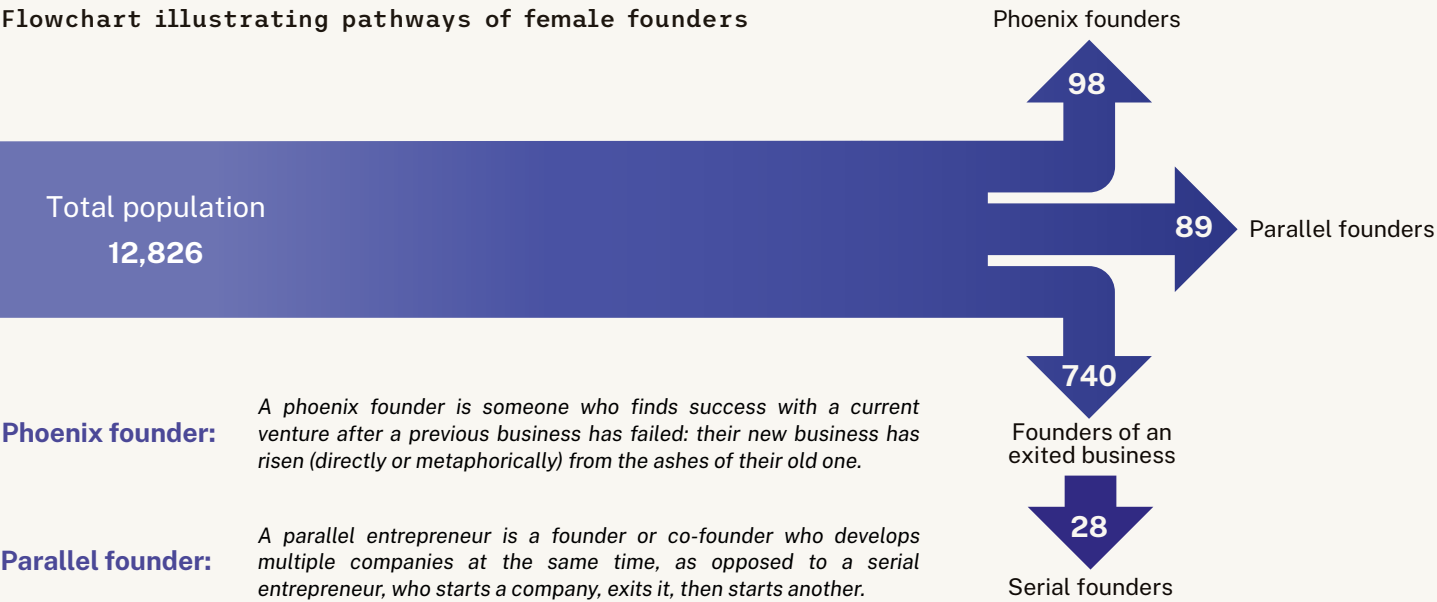
Top industries of high-growth female-founded companies (Nov 2024)

Application software	2,407
Online retailing	1,504
Software-as-a-Service (SaaS)	855
Mobile apps	731
Data provision and analysis	691
Tutoring, training, coaching and skills development	540
Marketing, branding and advertising	538
Distribution and wholesale	533
Artificial Intelligence	533
Human resources	525

The industry distribution of female-founded high-growth companies shows a strong focus on industries that leverage technological innovation and scalability. Ranking first on the list is application software (2,407), which is a trend that is mirrored across the broader high-growth landscape. This prevalence reflects the industry’s attractiveness due to its high scalability, broad applicability across industries, and the capacity to drive substantial growth with relatively low startup costs.

The presence of 1,504 active online retail companies emphasises the ongoing importance of digital commerce in the high-growth ecosystem. E-commerce offers founders a direct path to market, allowing them to respond swiftly to consumer preferences and capitalise on the shift toward digital purchasing habits. This industry representation highlights its growth potential supported by technological advancements in logistics, payment systems, and customer engagement tools.

Flowchart illustrating pathways of female founders



04

Survey findings

Survey findings

Female business owners in the UK are fostering mutual success despite the challenges they face. According to the *Charles Stanley Fortune Favours Survey*, 70.8% of the 250 female respondents want to support other women in business, while 72.8% aimed to mentor young business leaders. The survey, conducted among 500 UK business owners aged 18 and over with household incomes of at least £100k, included several questions directed exclusively at the 250 female participants. These questions focused on business topics, such as exit strategies and succession planning, as well as family financial dynamics and perceived challenges facing female business leaders.

Despite ongoing obstacles, 67.2% of female respondents reported feeling a responsibility to support peers within their industries. Notably, 46.0% agreed that starting a business today is easier than when they began, compared to 18.4% who disagreed, indicating that strides have been made towards a more inclusive business environment for women.

Only 8.40% of respondents indicated that they would become angel investors. This may be a result of female entrepreneurs having less access to capital, wealth accumulation, and established networks, which in turn

limits their resources and exposure to angel investment opportunities.

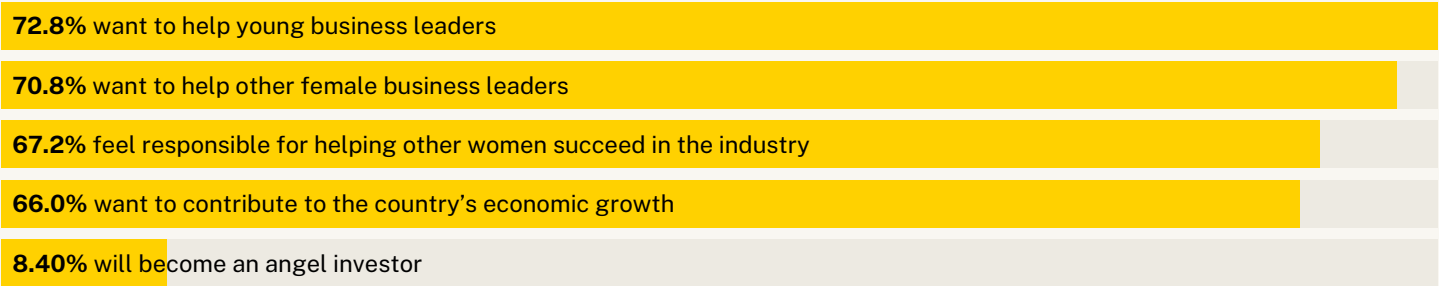
Prejudice is still prevalent for women in business, with over half of female business owners (53.6%) reporting experiences of sexism on their entrepreneurial journey. A majority of women business owners (55.2%) felt that being a woman subjected them to increased scrutiny. Unfortunately, 47.6% say that other aspects of their identity, including race and sexuality, have impacted their career more than their gender.

Support networks are important with 57.0% of women turning to advisors before setting up their business, particularly for advice on financing the company. Women tend to favour their partners for advice on personal finances (42.4%) but turn to financial advisers when it comes to business finance queries (36.8%).

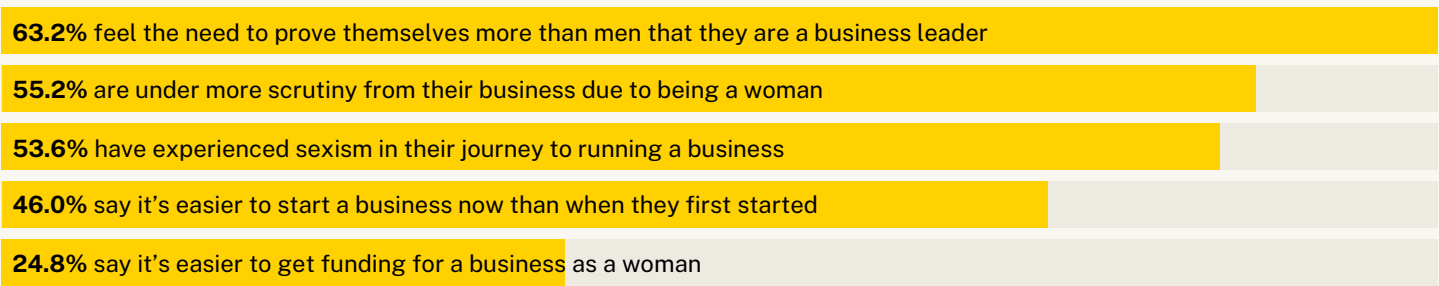
With 63.2% of women feeling they need to prove themselves more than men to be seen as business leaders, it's clear that perceptions need to change. The survey shows women feel a strong need to support each other, but there is still a responsibility for all business leaders to create a more inclusive environment for women founders.

Charles Stanley Fortune Favours Survey

Supporting women business founders (% of female business owners)



Prejudice towards women business founders (% of female business owners)

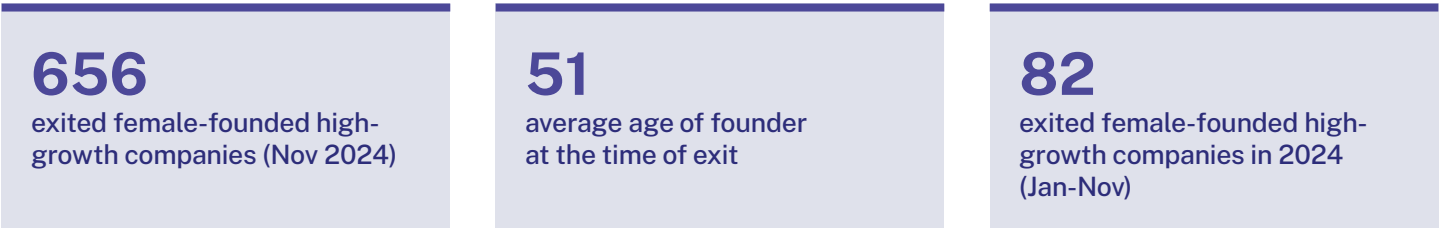


05

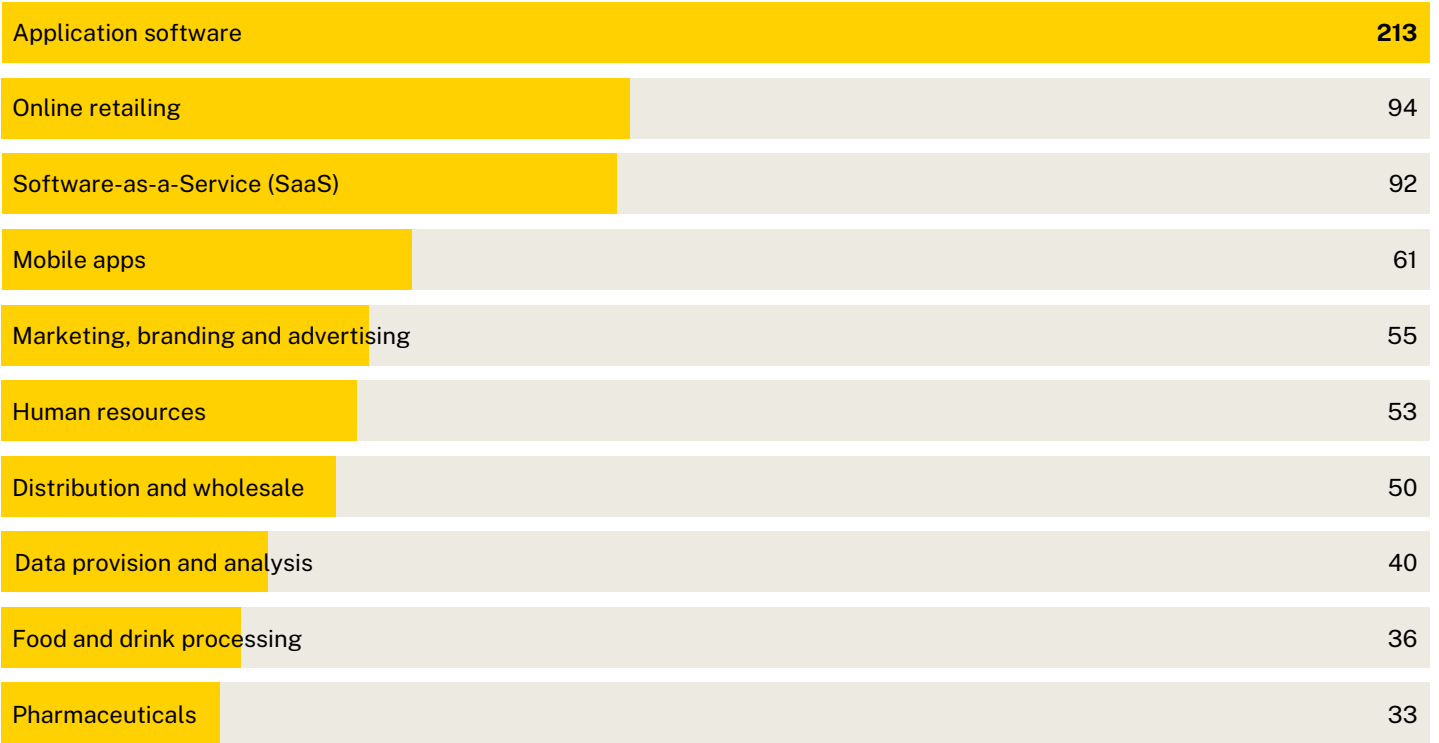
Exited female-founded businesses

Exited female-founded businesses

Key figures (Nov 2024)



Top industries of exited high-growth female-founded companies (Nov 2024)



Most exited female-founded companies are in technology-driven, scalable industries. This reflects the high concentration of these companies across the broader high-growth ecosystem. Application software tops the ranking with 213 companies undergoing an exit. Application software is appealing to founders and investors due to its low capital requirements combined with its potential for rapid growth.

Online retail follows with 94 exits, highlighting its strong position in the high-growth landscape. The industry’s ability to attract acquisitions and investment interest is

supported by consumer demand for e-commerce and the scalability of digital business models. Software-as-a-service (SaaS) also stands out with 92 exits, illustrating the appeal of recurring revenue models and their flexibility across multiple industries.

Female-founded companies are achieving significant exits across a wide array of industries. Their presence in capital-intensive industries such as food and drink processing (36 exits) and pharmaceuticals (33 exits) underscores their activity in areas that often face longer timelines and regulatory challenges.

06

Beyond the Exit: The next steps

Beyond the Exit:

The next steps

After exiting a business, many entrepreneurs consider different paths for their next steps, such as starting a new business, taking on advisory roles, or engaging in angel investing. According to the *Charles Stanley Survey*, 35.2% of female business owners expressed an interest in retiring to spend more time with family. A further 14.8% showed interest in becoming business or executive coaches, while 14.4% considered starting a new business. Other plans included becoming an angel investor (8.40%), a trustee (7.60%), or an employee at another business (6.40%).

“**Access to capital remains a barrier for women entrepreneurs, with less than 2% of equity funding going to female-founded businesses**”

This funding gap doesn't just impact women during the growth stages of their business but also influences their decisions after exiting a company. Some former

female founders turn to angel investing, as this allows them to support emerging businesses that may face similar financial hurdles. By providing capital and mentorship, these entrepreneurs help to sustain other startups, particularly those led by women or underrepresented groups.

In addition to investing, many entrepreneurs may choose paths that utilise their expertise without requiring the full-time commitment of running a business. *The Charles Stanley Survey* found that 15.6% of female business owners would step down or away from their businesses while still staying involved as a Chairman or NED once they exit or pass on the business. The survey also found that many female business owners feel a commitment to helping others; with 70.8% of respondents expressing a desire to support other female business leaders, and 72.8% stated they want to help younger business leaders.

Other former entrepreneurs may return to corporate roles or pursue further education. The decision on what to do next often depends on a combination of personal and professional factors. For some, work-life balance becomes more important after the demands of running a business. Financial stability also plays a significant role, with certain pathways offering more security.

Charles Stanley Fortune Favours Survey

Once you've exited the business, what, if anything, will your next steps be?
(% of female business owners)



07

Case studies

Debbie Woskow OBE:

Exited entrepreneur turned angel investor

Debbie Woskow OBE is a British entrepreneur and angel investor known for promoting female entrepreneurship. Her entrepreneurial journey started early, marked by winning an enterprise award at the age of 15. Woskow's early experiences sparked her interest in business and helped shape her future career path. In 2011, she co-founded Love Home Swap, a home exchange platform inspired by the film *The Holiday*. The platform enabled users to exchange homes for holidays. By 2017, it had grown to include over 100k homes across the world. Woskow sold the business to Wyndham Destination Networks for £40.0m in 2017.

Alongside her entrepreneurial ventures, Woskow has focused on supporting women in business. Drawing from her own experiences with the challenges women face in business, Woskow co-founded AllBright in 2017—a network and resource platform dedicated to supporting women entrepreneurs through mentorship, networking, and educational programmes. For example, AllBright provides access to a digital academy offering courses on leadership, financial literacy, and investment readiness, helping female founders build the necessary skills to grow their businesses. Through AllBright, Woskow aims to address the ongoing challenges that female founders face in securing funding and support. She explains: “We need to empower more women with the confidence to raise capital and equip them with the resources they need to do that effectively.”²

“
I want to make the UK the best place in the world to be a female founder by creating the biggest funding pot in the world to back female investors”

Woskow is an active angel investor and directs much of her investment toward female-led companies. She also serves as co-chair of the UK government's Invest in Women Taskforce, which was established this year with the aim of improving funding opportunities for female entrepreneurs. Woskow's ambition for the taskforce is clear: “I want to make the UK the best place in the world to be a female founder by creating the biggest funding pot in the world to back female investors.”³

Reflecting on the challenges faced by female entrepreneurs, she emphasises the importance of representation: “We need more female investors in the room to level the playing field. The knowledge around raising capital is really important.”⁴ This belief underpins much of her investment strategy. Beyond her work with female entrepreneurs, Woskow has contributed to broader policy discussions. In 2015, she led a UK government review on the sharing economy, which provided recommendations that helped shape regulations in this growing sector.

Woskow's contributions have not gone unrecognised. In 2016, she was awarded an OBE for her services to business. Her ongoing advocacy for female entrepreneurs and her efforts to reduce barriers for women in business continue to define her career.



Debbie Woskow OBE

Co-founder of Love Home Swap | angel investor | Co-founder of AllBright | Co-chair of the UK's Invest In Women Taskforce

²Barrett, Jennifer. “Female Entrepreneurship’s on the Rise—Will Funding Follow? AllBright Co-Founder Debbie Woskow Weighs In.” *Forbes*, December 28, 2021.

³Woskow, Debbie. “A Top Investor Talks Funding for Female Entrepreneurs.” *SheerLuxe*, August 7, 2019.

⁴Barrett, Jennifer. “Female Entrepreneurship’s on the Rise—Will Funding Follow? AllBright Co-Founder Debbie Woskow Weighs In.” *Forbes*, December 28, 2021.

Tamara Lohan:

Exited entrepreneur turned advisor/NED

In 2001, Tamara Lohan and her husband, James Lohan experienced a less-than-inspiring getaway at a spa in England's Lake District. Frustrated by the lack of high-quality and unique accommodations, the couple identified a gap in the market for discerning travellers seeking boutique hotel experiences. This insight led them to launch Mr & Mrs Smith in 2003—initially as a guidebook to boutique hotels. The company is named with a nod to the alias traditionally used by couples checking into hotels incognito.

After launching in 2003, Mr & Mrs Smith quickly resonated with an audience seeking curated recommendations. The first version of their guide sold 10,000 copies within six weeks, eventually surpassing 100,000.⁵ Recognising the potential of the internet, Lohan led the company's digital transformation in 2005, transitioning from print to an online platform. The shift positioned Mr & Mrs Smith as a key destination for those seeking travel advice and booking boutique accommodation online.

Under Lohan's leadership as Chief Technology Officer and later CEO, the business expanded its portfolio beyond hotels to include villas and exclusive travel experiences. By 2023, Mr & Mrs Smith boasted of over one million and featured more than 1,800 properties worldwide. The brand's emphasis on personalised service and quality curation distinguished it from traditional travel agencies. "Every single one of our hotels is unique—they're not cookie cutter," noted Lohan in a recent interview.⁶

In May 2023 Hyatt Hotels acquired Mr & Mrs Smith for £53m. Lohan remained at the helm as CEO to guide the integration while preserving the brand's distinctive ethos. The acquisition enabled the company to leverage Hyatt's resources to enhance its offerings further and reach new markets. Beyond her executive role, Lohan has transitioned into advisory positions, sharing her entrepreneurial acumen as a Non-Executive Director (NED) at Fortnum & Mason since June 2023. Her expertise in technology and marketing strategy contributes to the storied retailer's evolution in the digital age. She has also held a NED role at adventure travel firm Much Better Adventures since June 2021.

“When women fund other women, it creates a supportive ecosystem”

An advocate for women in business, Lohan invests in female-led enterprises and champions a more inclusive investment landscape. Reflecting on the importance of support networks, she has said, “When women fund other women, it creates a supportive ecosystem.”⁷ Her journey from a frustrated traveller to an accomplished entrepreneur and advisor highlights the value of vision, resilience, and a commitment to doing things differently.



Tamara Lohan MBE

Founder and CEO of Mr & Mrs Smith | Non-Executive Director at Fortnum & Mason and Much Better Adventures

⁵ Peter Shadbolt, “The Real-Life Couple Behind Hotels Website Mr & Mrs Smith,” *BBC News*, December 14, 2015, accessed October 28, 2024

⁶ Tamara Lohan, “My Business Journey: Tamara Lohan,” SheerLuxe, July 24, 2023, accessed October 28, 2024.

⁷ EnterpriseAlumni, “#BeMyAngel—Tamara Lohan MBE, CEO and founder of Mr & Mrs Smith,” Medium, March 4, 2024, accessed October 28, 2024.

Martha Lane Fox:

Exited entrepreneur starting another business

Martha Lane Fox rose to prominence in the late 1990s as the co-founder of Lastminute.com, an online travel and gift retailer specialising in distressed inventory. Founded in 1998 with Brent Hoberman, the company became emblematic of the dot-com boom. By January 2000, Lastminute.com had hundreds of thousands of regular users; its initial public offering (IPO) in March 2000 saw its valuation hit £571m. Despite the dot-com bust that followed, Lane Fox's leadership during this period cemented her status as a leading figure in the UK's internet economy.

Following her departure from Lastminute.com in 2003, Lane Fox continued to play an active role in the UK's entrepreneurial landscape. She co-founded Lucky Voice in 2005, redefining karaoke in the UK. As the UK's Digital Champion from 2009 to 2013, she led the Race Online 2012 campaign to bring millions more Britons online. In 2015, she founded Doteveryone, advocating for responsible technology. Appointed to the House of Lords in 2013 as a crossbench peer, she became its youngest female member. Lane Fox has a portfolio of responsibilities, including serving as Chancellor of the Open University, acting as a non-executive director at Chanel, and President of the British Chambers of Commerce.

Lane Fox's life took a dramatic turn in 2004 when a severe car accident in Morocco left her with lasting disabilities. Demonstrating remarkable resilience, she adapted to her new circumstances and channelled her experiences into philanthropic efforts. She is a patron of Day One Trauma Support, a charity providing help to those affected by major trauma. Her philanthropic endeavours extend through Antigone, a grant-making trust she established in 2007 to support UK charities in healthcare, education, criminal justice, and technology. Lane Fox's dedication to social justice is reflected in her patronage of organisations such as CAMFED which supports girls' education in Africa, and Just for Kids Law, which provides legal support to young people in the UK.

“Success is made up of thousands of small, boring, hard steps, and that is what makes success most likely”

Lane Fox recently climbed the UK's three highest peaks in 2024 to mark 20 years since her accident and to raise funds for four charities. She described climbing without seeing the summit as an analogy for starting new ventures: “I cannot think of a better metaphor for starting a business or any new project. You have your big idea but there is no shortcut to its realisation. You have to do all the small steps and the hard work, often with no idea which direction is up or when you will reach the outcome you desire. Success is made up of thousands of small, boring, hard steps, and that is what makes success most likely.”⁸



Baroness Martha Lane Fox
Serial entrepreneur, businesswoman,
and philanthropist

⁸Martha Lane Fox, “BHAGs – Big Hairy Audacious Goals,” Medium, October 8, 2024. Accessed October 28, 2024.

Eccie and Gini Newton:

Female entrepreneurs

Entrepreneurs and sisters Eccie and Gini Newton founded Karma Cans in 2014 as a corporate catering company, providing meals to offices across London. Inspired by Mumbai's dabbawala system, their concept involved delivering fresh, home-cooked lunches in reusable containers. This focus on sustainability and convenience made their service popular among corporate workers in the City.

As Karma Cans grew, the Newtons encountered logistical challenges, particularly around kitchen space. To manage increasing demand, they moved from a home kitchen to a larger facility. This experience highlighted an issue in the food industry: limited access to affordable, flexible commercial kitchen space. Realising that other small food businesses faced similar challenges, the sisters decided to address this issue with a new venture.

In 2018, the Newtons launched Karma Kitchen, a co-working kitchen space designed to provide small food businesses with affordable, flexible access to commercial kitchens. By offering shared, rentable kitchen spaces, Karma Kitchen helps reduce the financial burden of owning or leasing a private kitchen facility. This model allows emerging food businesses to focus on growing their businesses rather than worrying about the high cost of infrastructure.

As an experienced founder, Eccie advises other women pursuing entrepreneurship by saying: "The one thing I'd say to female entrepreneurs is to create your own space, one that suits you. Do your own thing early, and don't try to conform too much to a workplace that wasn't really created or designed for you [as women], because that can take away some of your self-confidence."⁹ Eccie also highlights another challenge for female founders, "There are not very many female founders in the UK that receive funding. There is a large intersectional group of people who contribute to the economy, who are consumers and members of our community, who are ignored when it comes to funding."¹⁰

For Eccie and Gini, more inclusive financing represents an ethical choice and a business opportunity. As Eccie explains, "Diverse financing has the potential to grow big successful businesses that capture wider audiences and more consumers."¹¹ Through Karma Kitchen, the sisters continue to support small businesses and advocate for inclusivity within the food industry.

Diverse financing has the potential to grow big successful businesses that capture wider audiences and more consumers"



Eccie and Gini Newton
Co-founders of Karma Cans
and Karma Kitchen

⁹"Meet Gini and Eccie Newton." Moving Ahead. Accessed October 29, 2024.

¹⁰"Eccie Newton." Swansea University: Founders of the Future. Accessed October 29, 2024.

¹¹"Eccie Newton." Swansea University: Founders of the Future. Accessed October 29, 2024.

08

Conclusion

Conclusion

The journey of female entrepreneurship in the UK continues to be marked by resilience, ambition, and a growing sense of community. This report has explored the significant contributions female founders make to the UK economy, as well as the barriers they still face.

Despite making up only 13.7% of the UK's high-growth company population, female-founded businesses employ over 300k people and have received £1.48b in equity funding in 2024. Yet, prejudice still exists towards women in businesses, and the challenges are even more pronounced for younger entrepreneurs who are building their networks and establishing their reputations.

The findings of the *Charles Stanley Survey* highlight the determination and support among female entrepreneurs.

The vast majority of women are committed to mentoring and uplifting their peers.

The strong network across female leaders is crucial as the UK works to create a more inclusive business environment. However, sexism and increased scrutiny persist, underscoring the need for systemic change.

Barriers that prevent women from entering the entrepreneurial landscape result in missed opportunities for new businesses and founders from a demographic that represents half of the UK population.

Addressing these issues is more than a matter of fairness; it is an economic imperative. Greater investment in female-founded businesses and increasing diversity within investment firms can drive innovation, resilience, and economic growth. Initiatives like AccelerateHer and efforts by angel investors and advocates, such as Debbie Wosskow and Tamara Lohan, play a pivotal role in increasing diversity and inclusion. They demonstrate the tangible benefits of diverse leadership, which extends beyond gender and encompasses varied backgrounds and experiences.

Seeking professional advice, planning ahead and gaining access to long-term support can be the difference between entrepreneurial success and failure. Charles Stanley offers a comprehensive suite of services designed to meet the needs of entrepreneurs at every stage of their journey – from founding a business to succession planning and exiting.

As female entrepreneurship gains momentum, the UK stands at a crossroads. Continued progress will require sustained commitment from policymakers, investors, and industry leaders. By creating an ecosystem that empowers women at every stage—from launching startups to scaling and exiting businesses—the UK can unlock the full potential of its female founders. This not only benefits the women themselves but enriches the entire high-growth sectors, laying the foundation for a more inclusive and innovative future.

Helping your business thrive, come rain or come shine.

As an entrepreneur, we know your business is your life's work, and Charles Stanley has been committed to helping businesses thrive for over 200 years.

By listening to your needs we can better steward your wealth so it can support your personal circumstances and ambitions, and the needs of your family and business.

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Investment involves risk



**CHARLES
STANLEY** 
Wealth Managers

Methodology

This report focuses on female-founded high-growth companies.

High-growth companies

Beahurst identifies high-growth and ambitious companies using eight triggers that suggest a company has high growth potential. More details on Beahurst's tracking triggers are available at beahurst.com

Female founded company

A female-founded company is defined as a high-growth company where at least one member of the founding team is known to be female. For a company to be predominantly female-founded, the founding team must be at least 51.0% female.

About us



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Production

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Design

Hannah Nicholls

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